

Master Audit: Expert Critiques & Proposals

The Hivemind has completed its ruthless evaluation of the *Zero Sum* framework. The consensus is that while the premise is terrifying and highly original, the mechanics and lore suffer from mathematical death spirals, legal vulnerabilities, and “cartoonish” narrative leaps.

Below is the consolidated critique and the proposed roadmap for V2.

1. Legal & Copyright (The Liability Pass)

- **Libel Risk (High):** Using 1:1 real-world figures (Elian Moss, Simon Apex-Sovereign) and assigning them massive felonies is actionable defamation. **Proposed Fix:** Decouple them. Create composite archetypes. Rename “Chirp” and “Omniverse” to distance from real trademarks.
- **Copyright Proximity:** “Cognitive Load Track” and “Fracture” are legally uncomfortably close to *Alien RPG*. **Proposed Fix:** Rename the mechanics to “**Cognitive Load**” and “**Psychological Burn**.”
- **Sovereign Void Fallacy:** International waters are not lawless; they are governed by flag-state UNCLOS laws. **Proposed Fix:** Reframe the Void as a “**Jurisdictional Labyrinth**.” PMCs don’t kill you because there are no laws; they kill you because the local magistrate is bought and the ship flies a Bahamian flag of convenience.
- **Parallel Construction Mechanics:** **Proposed Fix:** Make this an active battleground. If players realize they are being framed via parallel construction, give them legal/social mechanics to expose the “Fruit of the Poisonous Tree” and drop the charges.

2. Immersion & World-Building (The Coherence Pass)

- **The Unplayable Panopticon:** If facial recognition and AI are mathematically flawless, the players will die in session one. **Proposed Fix:** Introduce “**Systemic Rot**.” The surveillance

state is bloated, siloed, and corrupt. The NSA won't share facial recognition with corporate PMCs due to proprietary disputes. Cameras have blind spots because city councils embezzled the maintenance budgets.

- **Disaster Capitalism vs. Master Plan:** Claiming the Factions *started* the climate crisis and the Ukraine War is comic-book villainy. **Proposed Fix:** Pivot to pure **Disaster Capitalism**. The factions didn't start the fires, but they ruthlessly profit from them.
- **Algorithmic White-Listing:** To explain why PMCs can have shootouts while players get arrested for firing a 9mm, introduce **Cryptographic White-Listing**. PMCs carry tokens that tell city-wide acoustic sensors to ignore their gunfire. Players can steal or spoof these tokens to buy 5 minutes of consequence-free violence.

3. PnP Mechanics & Math (The Balance Pass)

- **Broken Difficulty Classes (DCs):** With successes on a 7-10 (40% chance), a 4-dice character has a mere 2.5% chance of passing a DC 4. This forces elite operators to act like amateurs. **Proposed Fix:** Lower the success threshold to **6+ (50% per die)** or firmly cap DCs at 3.
- **The Psychological Burn Death Spiral:** Permanently lowering Attributes due to Psychological Burn creates a death spiral where failing a roll permanently cripples your dice pool, guaranteeing more failures. **Proposed Fix:** Traumas should inflict **Situational Complications** (e.g., "Cannot reroll 1s", "Catatonia during ambushes") rather than permanently subtracting dice.
- **The ZSCM Script is "Fraudulent":** The Asymmetry theorem math currently breaks the 1-10 bounded scale by forcing the Antagonist Power up to 20. The footprint checking uses hard-coded city strings instead of systemic logic. **Proposed Fix:** Refactor the math to respect the 1-10 scale ($E = \min(10, \max(5, R + \lfloor I/2 \rfloor))$). Update the python script to assign and verify dynamic "Security Tiers" rather than parsing for specific city names.

If you approve these proposals, we can enact them across the repository immediately.